



Trailblazers: Ranked eighth in the world, Morocco (in white) arrives at its seventh World Cup buoyed by its historic run to the 2022 semifinals, the first by an African or Arab nation. GETTY IMAGES

been ravaged by injuries in recent years. The 34-year-old has seemingly proven his fitness over the last few months with Santos in a desperate push to make the cut.

While his return might appear to be Ancelotti placating the Brazilian desire for a totem, Neymar could be the spark the side needs, at least off the bench.

What Neymar could offer Brazil is an infusion of creativity, particularly against teams operating in well-organised low blocks, a prospect that looks highly likely in a tricky Group C.

Brazil's biggest obstacle in the group is likely to be Morocco, a side revelling in its golden era. After becoming the first African team to reach a World Cup semifinal in 2022, Morocco went on to win the AFCON title in 2025. The side also enjoyed a perfect qualification campaign, winning all eight of its group matches.

Much of Morocco's success has been built on its steely defensive compactness. The side conceded just two goals each during the qualifiers and AFCON 2025.

Leading the Moroccan defence will be Achraf Hakimi, arguably the best right-back in world football right now.

It is safe to assume that Morocco's attacking initiatives will be primarily channelled through the nimble-footed Real Madrid midfielder

ON THE RADAR



Casemiro (Brazil)

After enjoying a fruitful farewell season with Manchester United, Casemiro will anchor Brazil's midfield at the World Cup.

In addition to his resolute defensive qualities, Casemiro will also bring his aerial goal-scoring ability to the table, following a career-best haul of nine goals for United in 2025-26.



Achraf Hakimi (Morocco)

Over the last few years, Hakimi has made the right flank his own for both Morocco and Paris Saint-Germain, cementing his status as one of the finest wing-backs in world football.

At the World Cup, Morocco will lean heavily on the 27-year-old's electric pace and link-up play, both in attack and defence.